

The Well-Set Page

A specimen exercising every cascade component — the modular scale, optical profile, vertical rhythm, and theme — written about the craft it demonstrates.

Typography begins with one decision: the size of the body text. Everything else — the headings above it, the captions beneath, the space between the lines — follows from that size by *proportion* rather than by whim. A **modular scale** fixes those ratios, so a page holds together the way intervals hold a chord.

Body text asks to be read, not admired. It wants a comfortable measure — around sixty-six characters to the line — and leading loose enough to carry the eye back to the left margin without losing the row. The relevant knob is line-height; set it too tight and the lines congeal, too loose and they drift. The reasoning behind these defaults lives in [the notes](#).

The finer adjustments compound quietly.¹ Tracking opens at display sizes and closes at reading sizes; word spacing does the opposite. None of it should announce itself — the reader simply finds the page easy to move through.²³

On measure and rhythm

A column of text is a grid in disguise. Every line rests on an invisible baseline, and the space between paragraphs is a whole multiple of it, so the vertical rhythm never stumbles. Even inline code such as `font-size` is pulled onto the same measure.

Typography exists to honour content.

— Robert Bringhurst

A scale, from small to large

text-1 · caption and footnote size

text-2 · small print

text-3 · the reading size

text-4 · a subhead or lead

text-5 · a small display line

Principles

A few rules carry most of the weight:

- Contrast builds hierarchy — size, weight, and space, used sparingly.
- Restraint keeps that hierarchy legible; a page that shouts says nothing.
- Consistency is the quiet virtue: the same choice, made the same way, throughout.

Put plainly, the process is short:

1. Set the body size and the measure.
2. Derive every other size from the scale.
3. Let the rhythm follow from the leading.

¹Bringhurst calls these the micro-typographic controls — the ones a reader feels but never consciously notices.

²On the sixty-six-character line and much else, see Robert Bringhurst, *The Elements of Typographic Style*.

³And, on vertical rhythm specifically, the same volume's chapter on the baseline.

Bringhurst's comfortable measure runs 45–75 characters; cascade defaults to sixty-six.

```
#import "@local/cascade:0.1.0": layout
#let l = layout.make(scale: "golden-ditonic", measure:
66)
#show: l.page
#show: l.markup
```



Figure 1. A figure with its caption set in the caption style.
